Mission Command

Quick briefing

Explain how leaders apply mission command and choose a degree of control that fits the task, team, and risk.

Know the facts

Command and control · The exercise of authority and direction to accomplish the mission. Mission command is the approach that enables decentralized execution where appropriate.

Commander's intent · The purpose and desired outcome that guide subordinate judgment as conditions change.

Mission orders · Communicate the required result and relevant constraints, leaving decisions about execution to competent subordinate leaders where feasible.

Disciplined initiative · Acting on changing circumstances in support of the mission and within the commander's intent and assigned authority.

Seven principles · Competence, mutual trust, shared understanding, commander's intent, mission orders, disciplined initiative, and risk acceptance.

Prudent risk · A calculated exposure weighed against the mission benefit and measures available to protect the force.

Understand the reasoning

Tighter coordination makes sense when mistakes have immediate safety consequences. As proficiency and mutual trust grow, leaders can delegate more decisions.

A communications link helps headquarters and subordinates share updates. The team still needs a shared understanding of purpose and boundaries to act when an update is delayed.

Philippine Army classroom exercise

During a Philippine Army classroom practical, a classroom becomes unavailable and headquarters is briefly unreachable. The team leader has been authorized to use any approved room. The next phase still requires an instructor safety check.

Decision · Which decision can the team leader make, and which decision should remain under tighter control?

Worked analysis · Shift to an approved room and update headquarters when contact resumes. This meets the objective within delegated authority. Keep the instructor check before beginning the next phase. Delegating room selection saves time while retaining the control that protects participants.

How to practice

1 · State why the task matters and describe what completion looks like.

2 · Specify required limits, safety controls, and decisions the subordinate leader can make.

3 · Ask for a backbrief covering the purpose, constraints, and response to a likely disruption.

4 · Set the expected reporting points and adjust oversight as the team demonstrates competence.

Check yourself

How does commander's intent support initiative? · It gives subordinates the purpose and desired outcome they can use to judge a new situation.

What makes a risk prudent? · The leader assesses the exposure, applies available safeguards, and weighs the remaining risk against the mission benefit.

Course source

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